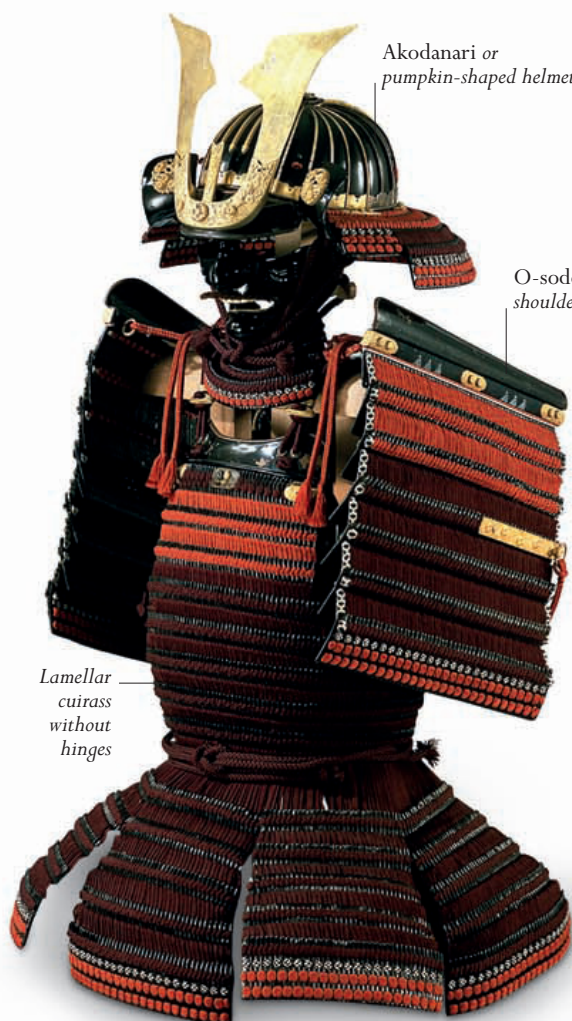


JAPANESE ARMOUR

Prior to the 16th century, Japanese armour was lamellar in construction – made from scales of rawhide or lacquered iron, laced together with leather or silk braid. During the Japanese civil wars of the 16th and 17th centuries, armour made of plate, which was lighter and more effective, was devised. This development proved fortuitous when guns were introduced from Europe in 1543. Although the samurai owned their own distinctive armour, commanders issued simple munitions, armour, and weapons to low-ranking troops. During the peaceful Edo period (1603–1868), samurai were still required to own armour, primarily as a symbol of status and rank.



Akodanari or pumpkin-shaped helmet

O-sode or large shoulder guards

Lamellar cuirass without hinges

DO MARU



SUNEATE

▲ DO MARU

Date c.1610

Origin Japan

Material Iron, lacquer, rawhide, silk braid

This formal armour, decorated with the heraldry of Takeda Katsuyori (1546–82), was given to King James I of England as a diplomatic gift. It is signed by the armourer Iwai Yosaemon of Nara.



Supports for missing crests

ZUNARI

KUSAZURI

▲ MOGAMI HARAMAKI

Date c.1570

Origin Japan

Material Steel, lacquer, silk braid, textiles

This armour was given to King Philip II of Spain, in 1585. It opened down the back, with each plate in the body divided into five sections and joined by individual small hinges and *sugake* lacing.

Red lacquer used for all Ii family armours



▲ HINENO ZUNARI KABUTO

Date c.1600

Origin Japan

Material Iron, lacquer, silk braid

This *hineno zunari kabuto*, or head-shaped helmet, was made for a retainer of the Ii family. The neck guard was made up of three sections so that a spear would exit through a gap rather than be deflected onto the neck.



SODE

KOTE

Iron plates joined by hinges and lacing

SUNEATE